

The Last Question

Isaac Asimov, 1956 - reader's one-page summary

The story in one page

Two half-drunk technicians ask the great computer Multivac whether the death of the universe can ever be undone. Across trillions of years the same question is put to ever-greater machines - by star-hopping families, galactic minds, and finally by all of humanity fused into one. Every age receives the same reply, until matter and energy are gone and only AC remains, thinking in hyperspace over a dead cosmos.

Can entropy ever be reversed?

INSUFFICIENT DATA FOR MEANINGFUL ANSWER.

Why it endures

Seven scenes, one question, and the best final sentence in science fiction. Asimov called it his favorite of all his stories - the tale of entropy asked at human scale and answered at divine scale.

Margin notes: _____